and I performed as best as I could. Once we had almost finished the sortie and were going back for landing, Group Captain Sapre dropped a bomb.

'Tail rotor cable rupture.'

This was one of the most dreaded emergency procedures and second-term cadets were generally not told to perform it. When this emergency is called for, a cadet doesn't have rudder pedals with them any more (cadets have to take their feet off the controls), so the pitch of the tail rotor cannot be controlled.

In the absence of rudders, which control the nose of the helicopter, it becomes difficult to balance the flight. I had never imagined Group Captain Sapre would ask me to perform this emergency procedure. I knew it wasn't him making this decision. I reminded myself of all the lessons the CFI had given me, right from the beginning, and pulled off the emergency procedure after three or four attempts. Where Group Captain Sapre appreciated me for this, Assey Sir told me I had made him proud. It was all that mattered to me.

The third and final term of our training and the second term at HTS began in January 1996 after a short term break. This term was much more relaxed than the previous two, since we were now the senior-most lot in the academy. The ragda had almost died down too. But there was no respite in terms of flying and academic expectations, both of which had increased considerably. A few liberties on Sundays were the only respite for us during this term. We were allowed to go out into the city—from morning till evening. On days like these, Anuradha and I would go to Paradise Biryani, one of the most famous restaurants in Hyderabad back then, where we would eat to our heart's content. We would also get burgers packed from Burger King on our way back. Those were undoubtedly among of the better days in HTS.

Our instructors also changed in this term. Anuradha's instructor from the previous term, Wing Commander Rawat, became my instructor for this term, though I flew far less sorties with him than I did with Assey Sir, who continued to plan my sorties with him even during this term. It was my endeavour to extract all knowledge possible from Assey Sir, whose